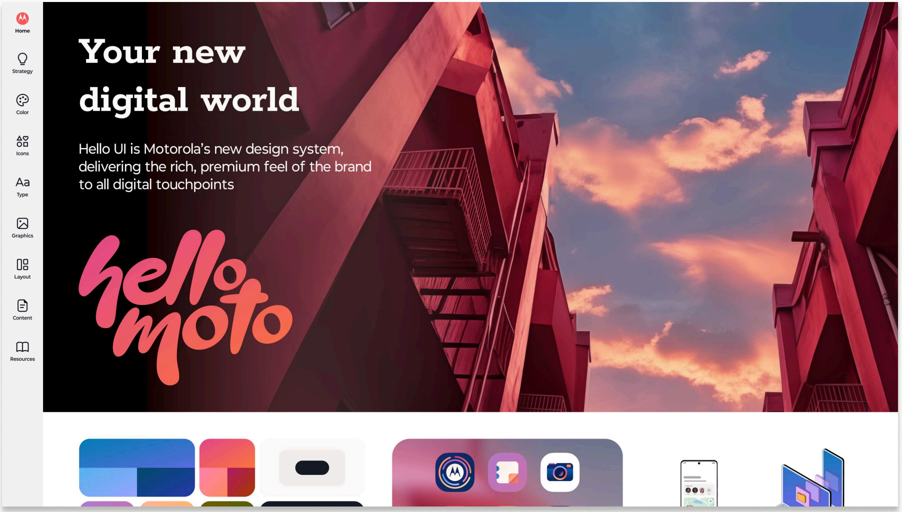
CASE STUDY / DESIGN SYSTEMS

Hello UI

Building Motorola's design system from the ground up — and getting people to actually use it.



CONTEXT	DURATION	ROLE	STATUS
Motorola — Hello UI Global digital touchpoints	2 months foundation to v1.0	Design Systems Lead Designer	Shipped Web + Mobile

THE THESIS

A design system isn't a component library.

It's a contract teams choose to honor.

Hello UI didn't win because the components were beautiful. It won because engineering, product, and design wanted to use it.

WHAT SHIFTED

~4–5 product teams adopting in first months
~30–40 components shipped with variants
Engineering went from "why?" to "what's next?"

Brand without a system.

Motorola had design assets — not a design system. Each product team interpreted the brand on their own. A Moto app could look like five different companies depending on who designed it.

The harder problem wasn't visual. It was cultural. Engineering saw a new system as more work for no clear gain.

> **"We don't need a new design system. We need a system people choose."**

THE THREE TENSIONS WE WALKED INTO

- **Inconsistent brand expression** across products
- **Material Design** being used straight, with no Moto identity
- **Engineering resistance** to adoption — and they were right

Strategy first. Pixels second.

Most design systems skip the strategy step and end up as glorified component libraries. We aligned on a position before we drew a single button.

PILLAR 01

Integrated Moto

A Motorola phone should feel like one. End to end. No seams between brand and OS.

PILLAR 02

Yes, AND...

We extend Material Design. We don't duplicate or fight it.Polish where it matters, leave the rest alone.

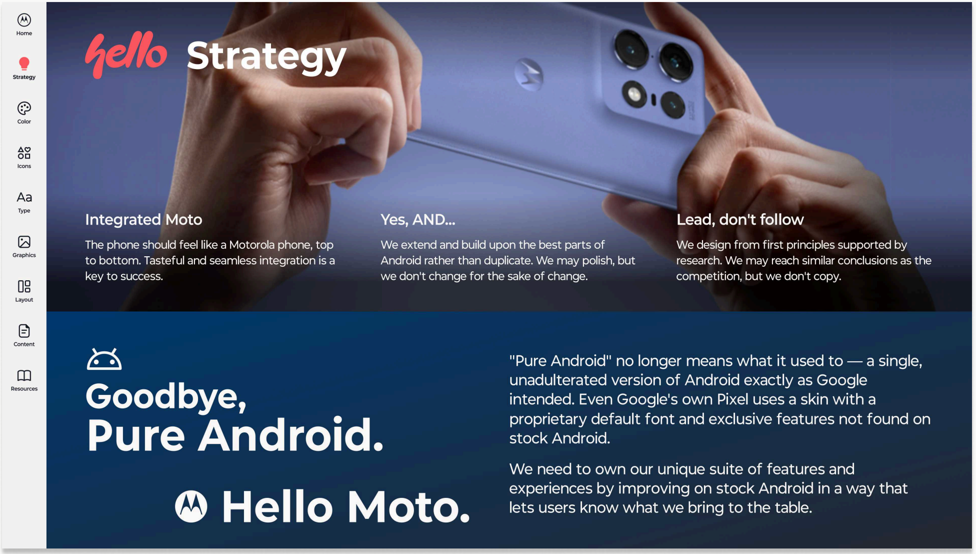
PILLAR 03

Lead, don't follow

We design from first principles. We may reach similar conclusions as competitors. We don't copy them.

From these three pillars came four design principles — Human, Confident, Authentic, Crafted — which became the lens for every later decision.

Strategy lives inside the system — not in a deck nobody reads.



Every team using Hello UI sees the strategy on the first page of the system. It's not aspirational — it's the working contract.

- **3 pillars** set the positioning
- **4 design principles** turn positioning into decisions
- Every component, token, and template gets reviewed against them

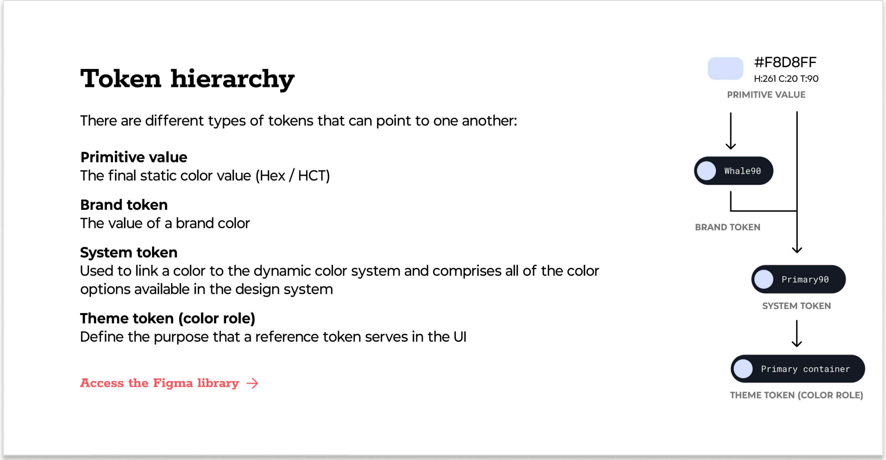
When someone proposed a new pattern, the question became: **"Is this Confident? Is this Crafted?"**

Tokens are the language design and engineering speak together.

We built a four-tier hierarchy so a designer never thinks in hex codes and an engineer never hardcodes a value.

- **Primitive value -** raw hex / HCT
- **Brand token -** Whale 90
- **System token -** Primary 90
- **Theme token (color role) -** Primary container

Change a brand color in one place. It propagates across every screen, every theme, every product. WCAG AA contrast was built in from day one — not patched at the end.



Extend Android. Don't fight it.

Theme comparison

The Moto theme uses Vellum for both neutral ranges and customized tonal values for some tokens.

	Moto Light ACCENT COLORS	Material Light ACCENT COLORS	Moto Dark ACCENT COLORS	Material Dark ACCENT COLORS
PRIMARY	PRIMARY PRIMARY-50	PRIMARY PRIMARY-40	PRIMARY PRIMARY-80	PRIMARY PRIMARY-80
	ON PRIMARY PRIMARY-100	ON PRIMARY PRIMARY-100	ON PRIMARY PRIMARY-20	ON PRIMARY PRIMARY-20
	PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-90	PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-90	PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-30	PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-30
	ON PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-10	ON PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-10	ON PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-90	ON PRIMARY CONTAINER PRIMARY-90
SECONDARY	SECONDARY SECONDARY-50	SECONDARY SECONDARY-50	SECONDARY SECONDARY-80	SECONDARY SECONDARY-80
	ON SECONDARY SECONDARY-100	ON SECONDARY SECONDARY-100	ON SECONDARY SECONDARY-20	ON SECONDARY SECONDARY-20
	SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-90	SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-90	SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-30	SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-30
	ON SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-10	ON SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-10	ON SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-90	ON SECONDARY CONTAINER SECONDARY-90
TERTIARY	TERTIARY TERTIARY-50	TERTIARY TERTIARY-40	TERTIARY TERTIARY-80	TERTIARY TERTIARY-80
	ON TERTIARY TERTIARY-100	ON TERTIARY TERTIARY-100	ON TERTIARY TERTIARY-20	ON TERTIARY TERTIARY-20
	TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-90	TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-90	TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-30	TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-30
	ON TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-10	ON TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-10	ON TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-90	ON TERTIARY CONTAINER TERTIARY-90
PRIMARY FIXED	PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-90	PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-90	PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-90	PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-90
	PRIMARY FIXED DIM PRIMARY-80	PRIMARY FIXED DIM PRIMARY-80	PRIMARY FIXED DIM PRIMARY-80	PRIMARY FIXED DIM PRIMARY-80
	ON PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-10	ON PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-10	ON PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-10	ON PRIMARY FIXED PRIMARY-10
	ON PRIMARY FIXED VARIANT PRIMARY-30	ON PRIMARY FIXED VARIANT PRIMARY-30	ON PRIMARY FIXED VARIANT PRIMARY-30	ON PRIMARY FIXED VARIANT PRIMARY-30
SECONDARY FIXED	SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-90	SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-90	SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-90	SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-90
	SECONDARY FIXED DIM SECONDARY-80	SECONDARY FIXED DIM SECONDARY-80	SECONDARY FIXED DIM SECONDARY-80	SECONDARY FIXED DIM SECONDARY-80
	ON SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-10	ON SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-10	ON SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-10	ON SECONDARY FIXED SECONDARY-10
	ON SECONDARY FIXED VARIANT SECONDARY-30	ON SECONDARY FIXED VARIANT SECONDARY-30	ON SECONDARY FIXED VARIANT SECONDARY-30	ON SECONDARY FIXED VARIANT SECONDARY-30
TERTIARY FIXED	TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-90	TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-90	TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-90	TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-90
	TERTIARY FIXED DIM TERTIARY-80	TERTIARY FIXED DIM TERTIARY-80	TERTIARY FIXED DIM TERTIARY-80	TERTIARY FIXED DIM TERTIARY-80
	ON TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-10	ON TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-10	ON TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-10	ON TERTIARY FIXED TERTIARY-10
	ON TERTIARY FIXED VARIANT TERTIARY-30	ON TERTIARY FIXED VARIANT TERTIARY-30	ON TERTIARY FIXED VARIANT TERTIARY-30	ON TERTIARY FIXED VARIANT TERTIARY-30
INVERSE	INVERSE PRIMARY PRIMARY-80	INVERSE PRIMARY PRIMARY-80	INVERSE PRIMARY PRIMARY-50	INVERSE PRIMARY PRIMARY-40

Android uses Google's Monet algorithm to generate themes from a user's wallpaper. We adapted it — but customized the neutral ranges with a Moto color called **Vellum**.

Result: the device feels distinctly Moto even when personalized. Engineering cost stayed low because the underlying structure was familiar.

This was "Yes, AND" in practice. We didn't reinvent dynamic color. We made it ours where it counted, kept Material where it worked.

Screens aren't generic surfaces. They have jobs.

A common design system mistake is treating every screen the same. We mapped three core moments — each with its own qualities, layouts, and templates.

MOMENT 01

Discover

User goal: explore features, take action.

Qualities: impactful, editorial, image-driven.

Examples: value props, splash screens, tutorials.

MOMENT 02

Launch

User goal: find and enter experiences.

Qualities: atmospheric, immersive, infinite.

Examples: home screen, lock screen, app tray.

MOMENT 03

Configure

User goal: adjust settings, enable features.

Qualities: minimal, high-contrast, uncluttered.

Examples: system settings, dashboards, index pages.

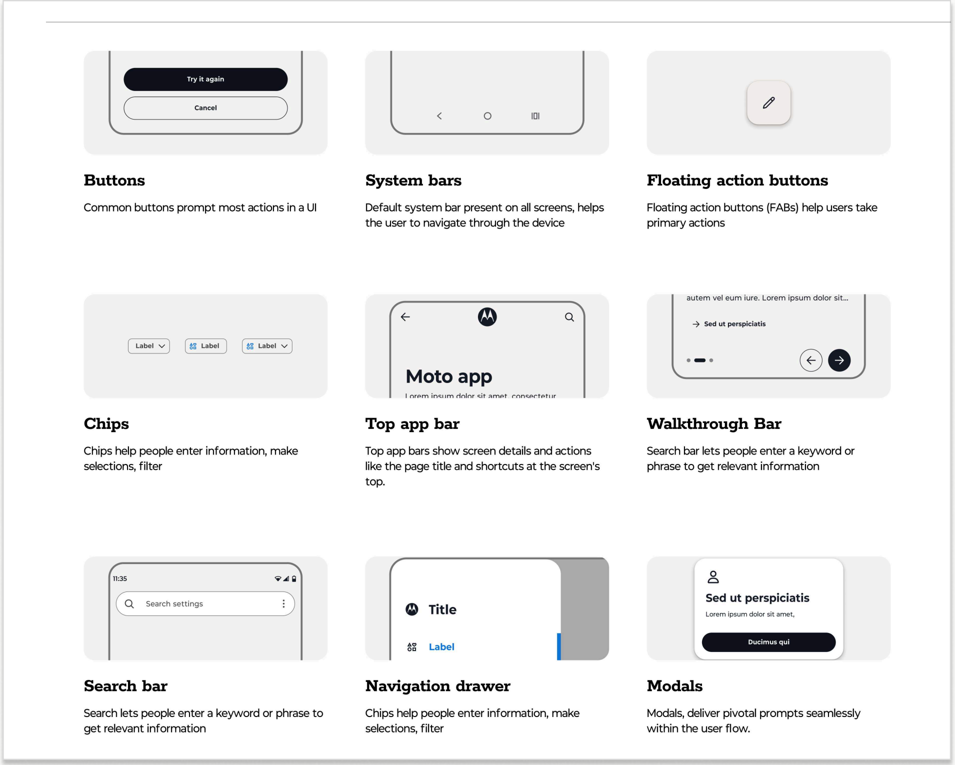
Teams stopped asking **"which button do I use?"** and started asking **"which moment am I designing for?"**

That shift changed how the org thought about consistency.

A library that grew with the product — not against it.

Components were built in Figma with variables, variants, and properties. Templates organized by moment so designers could start from a base, not a blank canvas.

- **~30–40 components** with variants by v1.0
- **500+ system icons** across 4 optimized sizes
- **Editable templates** per moment, ready to fork
- **Web + mobile** coverage from the same source of truth



Building the system is the easy half.
Getting people to use it is the job.

Engineering pushback was real. And fair. So we treated adoption as a design problem, not a marketing one.

MOVE 01

Three-tier library architecture

Brand library → Styles & Components → Templates. People found what they needed without getting lost in one giant file.

MOVE 02

Built-in contribution model

A Make a Request system inside the guidelines.Designers and engineers could flag gaps and propose changes. The system stopped being ours.

MOVE 01

Built on Material, not against it

The biggest unlock. Engineers were already fluent in Material. We extended what they knew instead of asking them to learn a new world.

AI-assisted workflows change what a systems designer can own.

I've been actively exploring **MCP servers, Cursor**, and design-to-code automation on personal projects.

I haven't shipped production code with them yet. But I've seen enough to believe this shifts the boundary between design and implementation — and that's exactly the boundary I want to keep crossing.

WHAT I'VE TOUCHED

- **MCP server setups** for token sync between Figma and code
- **Cursor / Claude Code** for component generation and refactor
- **Design-to-code prototypes** exploring Storybook integration

HOW I FRAME IT

Honest: I'm a designer who understands implementation, not an engineer. The growth I want is to go deeper into code alongside engineers — that's what makes this role land for me.

We were early. The numbers are directional. The change in the room was not.

~4–5

Product teams adopting in the first months

Tracked through Figma library usage

~30–40

Components with variants shipped by v1.0

Across web and mobile

~50%

Time saved on routine screens, per designer feedback

Anecdotal — not formal time-tracking

500+

System icons across 4 optimized sizes

Filled + outlined sets

> The bigger shift was cultural. Engineering conversations went from **"why are we doing this?"** to **"when's the next batch of tokens?"**
>
> That, to me, is the real ROI of a design system.

Two frictions I'd close earlier next time.

FRICTION 01

Instrument adoption metrics from day one.

We measured too late. Library usage, time-to-ship, design debt — those should be wired in before the system ships, not after the first wave of adoption.

FRICTION 02

Bring engineering into the strategy phase, not just implementation.

Co-ownership has to start before line one of code. We did it well in execution. Earlier would have made the buy-in easier.

> Senior judgment isn't shipping perfect. It's knowing which imperfections are safe to ship — and which ones you'd close earlier next time around.

EXPLORE THE GUIDELINES PROTOTYPE

Figma guidelines prototype link

Thanks for reading.